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DEMOCRACY – ECONOMIC INEQUALITY AND DEMOCRATIC BACKSLIDING : A SCOPING REVIEW¹

ABSTRACT

Background : Rising economic inequality and democratic backsliding are two defining trends of the 21st century. While a growing body of research examines their relationship, it remains unclear how economic inequality is conceptualized, measured, and empirically linked to democratic backsliding across the literature.

Objectives : This study maps the existing empirical research on the relationship between economic inequality and democratic backsliding published before 2026. 3 research questions are asked : (1) what patterns exist between the publications related to economic inequalities and democratic backsliding ; (2) how does the empirical literature conceptualize, measure, and analyze this relationship

Using a scoping review methodology, the paper identifies dominant theoretical frameworks, data sources, methodological approaches, and reported empirical patterns. Rather than adjudicating causal claims, the review clarifies where scholarly consensus exists, where findings diverge, and where significant research gaps remain.

Methods : The Eligibility Criteria compelled empirical examination of economic, income, or wealth inequality as an explanatory variable of democratic backsliding, using quantitative, qualitative, or mixed-methods approaches. Additionally, the paper needs to be published in English in peer-reviewed journals between 2000 and 2025. The systematic Web of Science and Scopus research produced 552 articles among which I retained 24 journal articles for manual coding. I then used mixed-methods to detect patterns in literature through quantitative methods, before conducting an in-depth analysis.

Results : The 24 selected articles were published between 2012 and 2025 with 50% published after 2022. Most of the articles were conducted in North America (37%), Asia (29%) and Europe (29%). A huge majority was based on an economics (42%) or political sciences -33%) point of view, favourising statistical approaches (92%). Whereas the operationalisation of economic inequalities and democratic backsliding was diverse and acknowledge a causal positive relation between the two, studies often adopted an occidental point of view potentially misleading.

KEYWORDS

Economic inequality, democratic backsliding, scoping review, PRISMA-ScR

1. Words $\approx$ 5,600

1. Introduction

1.1 Rationale

The 21st century is characterised by two parallel and potentially interconnected developments : rising economic inequality within many democracies and a widespread erosion in the quality of democratic institutions. This state-led debilitation or elimination of any political institutions that sustain an existing democracy is referred to as democratic backsliding (Bermeo, 2016). This process is often gradual, institutional, and legal—distinguishing it from sudden democratic breakdowns such as coups d'état. This temporal coincidence has generated increasing scholarly interest in whether, and how, economic inequality contributes to democratic decline. In this paper, I adopt a broad definition of economic inequality : all disparities in the distribution of economic resources among individuals or households within a society. The objective is to cover two central dimensions : (i) income inequality—unequal distribution of annual monetary earnings ; and (ii) wealth inequality—unequal distribution of accumulated assets.

Theoretical accounts offer competing explanations for how economic inequality may affect democratic stability. On one hand, the power conversion hypothesis suggests that high inequality allows economic elites to translate wealth into political influence, undermining political equality and institutional integrity (Acemoglu, 2006). In this view, economic inequality fosters a feedback loop where wealth buys influence, influence protects wealth, and democratic institutions gradually become hollowed out or biased toward elite interests—a dynamic often described as oligarchic drift or political inequality.

On the other hand, the redistributive mobilisation hypothesis posits that inequality can stimulate demands for redistribution, thereby enhancing democratic accountability through electoral pressure (Meltzer & Richard, 1981). According to this perspective, as inequality increases, the median voter—whose income typically falls below the mean—has a stronger incentive to demand redistributive policies through the ballot box. This electoral pressure can lead to progressive taxation, expanded social spending, and institutional reforms that enhance accountability, thereby strengthening rather than weakening democracy. Inequality, in this framework, acts as a catalyst for political engagement and democratic deepening, forcing governing elites to respond to popular demands or risk electoral defeat.

A third, contingent perspective argues that the effect of inequality is mediated by institutional and societal conditions—such as the strength of civil society or the autonomy of the state—which determine whether disparities fuel democratic erosion or reinforcement. Scholars in this vein argue that the impact of economic disparities on democracy is mediated by intervening variables such as the strength of civil society, the autonomy of political institutions, the level of social trust, and the structure of party systems. For example, in contexts with robust labour unions, independent judiciaries, and programmatic political competition, inequality may indeed spur democratic accountability. Conversely, in settings with weak institutions, fragmented opposition, or high levels of corruption, inequality is more likely to fuel clientelism, populist backlash, or authoritarian consolidation.

These divergent theoretical expectations help explain the fragmented and often contradictory empirical findings in the literature, motivating a scoping review to synthesise findings for both researchers and policymakers.

1.2 Objectives

The diversity of concepts, data, and methods complicates cumulative knowledge building. A scoping review is therefore appropriate to systematically map this heterogeneous field, clarify patterns, and identify gaps for future research. This article offers the first scoping review of the empirical literature testing the relationship between economic inequality and democratic backsliding. This review combines systematic search strategies and manual coding, covering 552 peer-reviewed articles available on the Web of Science and the Scopus databases by the end of December 2025. This paper addresses the following research questions :

RQ₁ : What descriptive patterns exist between the publications related to economic inequalities and democratic backsliding ?

RQ₂ : How does the empirical literature conceptualise, measure, and analyse the relationship between economic inequality and democratic backsliding ?

RQ₃ : What vacuums exist ?

First, I present the methodology used for transparency and replicability. It details the protocol and the selection of the corpus, as well as the items of interest. Second, it presents the results and explains what they signify about the current state of the art. Third, the discussion summarises the evidence to offer a synthesis of the literature and the limitations of the scoping review process.

Throughout the process, I successively use several software packages and websites. I used Web of Science and Scopus for the article databases, Excel for the creation of my original database, Lucidchart for the creation of graphics, and R for the quantitative analysis.

2. Methodology

2.1 Protocol

This study follows a scoping review design, which is particularly suited to mapping broad, heterogeneous literatures and clarifying how a research field is structured (Arksey & O'Malley, 2005). The review adheres to the PRISMA-ScR (Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses Extension for Scoping Reviews) guidelines to ensure transparency and replicability.

2.2 Eligibility Criteria

To ensure a focused and recent corpus on the 21st century's democratic backslide trends, the search was limited to publications from 2000 to 2025 to maximise the relevance to contemporary debates.

To ensure the match with the research questions, the articles must explicitly examine economic, income, or wealth inequality as an independent, mediating, or moderating variable. Studies focusing solely on political, social, or gender inequality without economic dimensions were excluded. Additionally, included studies must address democratic backsliding, erosion, decline, or autocratisation as a dependent variable or central outcome. This includes both gradual institutional degradation and abrupt democratic breakdowns, measured objectively (e.g., V-Dem, Polity) or subjectively (e.g., public support for democracy).

Also, only empirical studies employing quantitative, qualitative, or mixed-methods designs were retained to best align with the map of empirical evidence dimension. Theoretical essays, purely normative contributions, literature reviews, and editorials were excluded.

Naturally, included articles must be peer-reviewed journal articles to ensure scholarly rigour and credibility. Books, book chapters, working papers, conference proceedings, and policy reports were excluded. Finally, studies must be written in English and include an abstract to facilitate screening and data extraction. As a result, studies were included if they follow the criteria presented in Table 1 :

TABLE 1 – Inclusion criteria for scoping review

Criterion	Requirement
Independent variable	Empirically examined economic, income, or wealth inequality as an explanatory or conditioning factor
Dependent variable	Addressed democratic backsliding, democratic erosion, decline, or autocratisation as an outcome
Methodology	Used quantitative, qualitative, or mixed-methods approaches
Publication type	Published in peer-reviewed journals
Time period	Published between 2000 and 2025
Abstract	Had an abstract
Language	Written in English

2.3 Information Sources

The review relies on searches conducted in January 2026 in Scopus and Web of Science (WoS), the two most comprehensive and authoritative multidisciplinary citation databases for peer-reviewed literature. This dual-database approach is standard in systematic scoping reviews to maximise coverage while ensuring quality. Scopus is renowned for its extensive inclusion of social science journals and robust abstract indexing, while Web of Science provides rigorous coverage of high-impact journals through its selective curation. Using both databases mitigates the risk of missing relevant studies due to the unique coverage of each, increases the reproducibility of the search, and enhances the scholarly credibility of the resulting corpus by focusing on established, peer-reviewed outlets.

2.4 Search Strategy

Searches were performed on titles, abstracts, and keywords using Boolean combinations of inequality-related and democracy-related terms :

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("economic inequalit*" OR "income inequalit*" OR "wealth inequalit*"
OR "Gini" OR "top income share")
AND
("democratic backsliding" OR "democratic erosion" OR "democratic decline"
OR "autocratization")
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The keywords have been selected over an iterative process of adjustment to find the most

relevant literature. The name of the main variables of interest (economic inequalities, democratic backsliding) was simply written in the first step. Because the number of results was too low, I extended this first try by a second version including extending words referring to the same processes (income and wealth inequalities, democratic erosion and decline, and autocratisation). After a quick reading of the corpus, it appears that the term "economic inequalities" was often omitted in the titles, abstracts, and keywords to directly mention the name of the indicators. This explains why the last version of the key terms also includes the top indicators used to measure economic inequalities (Gini and top income share).

The results cover all research on the subject until December 2025 ($N = 552$; last search in January 2026). It merges searches on the Web of Science ($N = 18$) and the Scopus databases ($N = 534$).

2.5 Selection of Sources of Evidence

The study selection process followed four stages : identification, screening, check of eligibility, and inclusion. A PRISMA flow diagram (Figure 1) documents this process, resulting in a final corpus of 25 studies. I manually screened the articles in two steps : first through title, abstract,

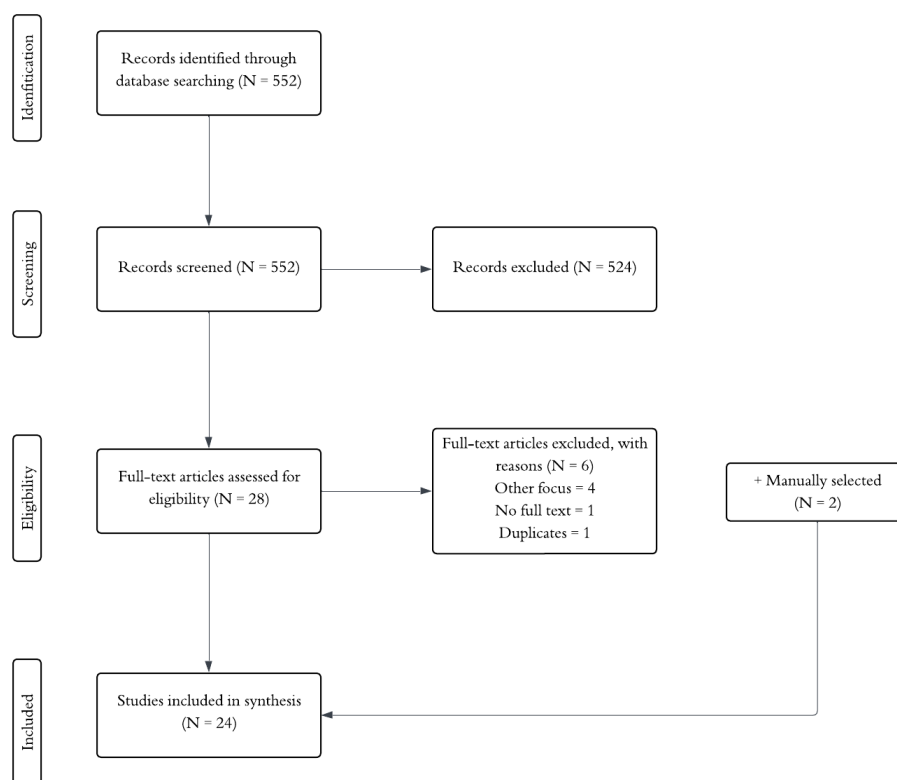


FIGURE 1 – Selection of the corpus

and keywords and second through full texts. The first step consists of an identification of the references that look relevant. In case of uncertainty, I privileged inclusion in order to avoid a withdrawal of potentially useful sources. During the full text reading, I found two references repeatedly cited (one from Kriekhaus et al., 2014) and (one from Andersen, 2012), and after a reading of them, it appears that they fitted with the problematic, so I manually added them.

2.6 Data Items

This review draws on an original database on economic inequalities and democratic backsliding, developed in Excel specifically for the purposes of this study. Each full-text article was carefully reviewed and coded using a standardised extraction grid (Table 2). To enhance the clarity of this scoping review, the collection of data items and the presentation of results follow the structure of a conventional scientific article. The analysis begins with a presentation of each paper, followed by a discussion of its theoretical and conceptual contributions. The methods and data are then described, before turning to the main findings and the identification of remaining gaps in the literature.

3. RESULTS

Table 2 presents the data extraction framework used in the scoping review. It includes key elements relevant to addressing Research Question 1, such as authorship, year of publication, and study motivation. In addition, the table incorporates variables that are essential for Research Questions 2 and 3, including definitions and measures of democracy and democratic backsliding, methodological approaches, and data sources.

Such a database will be useful for a preliminary quantitative analysis to catch some trends in the literature via a computing of frequency of characteristics. Also, it offers an intuitive way to gather the information.

TABLE 2 – Data Extraction

Authors	Year	Region	Keywords	Motivation	Field	Meth. ^a	Period	LOA ^b	N	Inequality Var.	Democracy Var.	Main Findings
Andersen, R.	2012	North America	Income inequality ; Modernization ; Former Communist rule ; Democracy ; Public opinion	General rise in inequalities	Sociology	1	2001	1	35	Gini	World Values Survey	National income inequality significantly reduces citizen support for democracy in established and former Communist nations.
Basihos, S.	2025	Europe	Democracy ; Market power ; Political power ; Markups ; Democratic backsliding	General democratic backsliding	Economics	1	1990–2019	1	80	Aggregate markups	V-Dem Electoral Democracy Index	Concentration of firm market power leads to a concentration of political power that undermines democracy.
Brzezinski, M. et al.	2022	Europe	Income inequality ; Gini index ; Top income shares ; Tax records ; Poland	Specific Geopolitical event	Economics	1	1994–2015	1	1	Gini ; top income shares	Polish Household Budget Survey ; tax records	Underestimated income inequality converges to high EU levels, fueling Poland’s populist and illiberal turn.
Deinla, I. B. et al.	2025	Asia	Democratization ; institutional trust ; political values ; Philippines ; clustering	General democratic backsliding	Political Science	1	2022	1	1	Income brackets	Institutional trust vs. democratic values	Economic inequality underpins authoritarian attitudes ; high-income youth are more engaged with democratic norms.
Dorsch, M. T. ; Maarek, P.	2020	Europe	Democratization ; Distributive conflict ; Inequality ; Window of opportunity ; Growth	General democratic backsliding	Economics	1	1973–2012	1	90	Gini	FH_iPolity2	Inequality increases the likelihood of democratic improvements specifically following economic downturns.
Han, S.	2025	Asia	Economic inequality ; strongman leadership ; subjective class ; backsliding	General democratic backsliding	Political Science	1	1994–2022	1	92	Subjective class	World Values Survey	Perceptions of Very Low or Very High class status (inequality) increase support for personalist strongman leadership.

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Authors	Year	Region	Keywords	Motivation	Field	Meth. ^a	Period	LOA ^b	N	Inequality Var.	Democracy Var.	Main Findings
Han, S.	2024	Asia	democratic backsliding ; political behaviour ; subjective stratification ; wealth inequality	General rise in inequalities	Political Science	1	1994–2022	1	92	Wealth Gini ; Top 1%	V-Dem Electoral/ Liberal/ Participatory	Rising wealth inequality shrinks the pro-democratic subjective middle class, leaving institutions more vulnerable.
Han, S. M. ; Chang, E. C. C.	2016	North America	Economic inequality ; Democratic legitimacy ; Democratic satisfaction ; Winner-loser gap	General democratic backsliding	Political Science	1	1996–2010	1	43	Gini	CSES Modules 2 & 3	High income inequality widens the satisfaction gap between winners and losers, destabilizing democratic legitimacy.
Houle, C.	2024	North America	inequality ; autocratization ; backsliding ; populism ; executive constraints	General democratic backsliding	Political Science	1	1961–2019	1	102	Gini ; top 1%	V-Dem (EDI) ; ERT dataset	Income inequality increases the incentives for the poor to support populists, leading to democratic backsliding.
Islam, M. R.	2018	Oceania	Wealth inequality ; Economic freedom ; Democracy ; Panel data	General rise in inequalities	Economics	1	2000–2014	1	46	Top 1% & 10% Wealth	Polity IV (Polity2)	Wealth inequality hampers economic freedom (property rights) ; democracy mitigates this adverse effect.
Jung, F. ; Sunde, U.	2014	Europe	Inequality ; Income ; Democracy ; Coalition formation ; Factor endowments	General democratic backsliding	Economics	1	1871–1945	1	1	Factor endowments	Pareto Coefficient Alpha	Stable democracy emerges only with moderate inequality ; high inequality results in oligarchies or mass dictatorships.
Kang, S. J. ; Seo, H. J.	2023	Asia	Democracy ; Meltzer and Richard hypothesis ; Redistribution ; Market inequality	General rise in inequalities	Economics	1	1990–2018	1	164	Market Gini	BMR ; CGV ; Polity V	High "political inequality" allows elites to capture the state, preventing democracy from reducing income inequality.

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Authors	Year	Region	Keywords	Motivation	Field	Meth. ^a	Period	LOA ^b	N	Inequality Var.	Democracy Var.	Main Findings
Koos, A. K.	2025	North America	democratic backsliding; populism; anti-pluralism; economic inequality	General democratic backsliding	Political Science	1	1970–2022	1	169	Resource distribution	V-Party Populism/Anti-Pluralism indexes	Economic inequality increases receptivity to anti-pluralist appeals, weakening commitment to democratic rules.
Kotschy, R.; Sunde, U.	2017	Europe	Gini coefficient; Economic institutions; Democratic institutions; Inequality	General democratic backsliding	Economics	1	1970–2010	1	96	Net Gini	PolityIV Constraints on Executive	Excessive inequality erodes the efficacy of democracy in establishing high-quality economic institutions.
Kriekhaus, J. et al.	2014	North America	Economic Inequality; Democratic Support; Retrospective evaluations; Sociotropic Inequality	General rise in inequalities	Political Science	1	1995–2008	1	40	Gini	World Values Survey	Economic inequality is the single largest determinant of democratic support; citizens respond sociotropically.
Lee, S. K.	2024	Asia	Democracy; Liberalism; backsliding; authoritarian inclination	General democratic backsliding	Sociology	1	1995–2020	1	41	Palma Ratio; 90-10	World Values Survey; V-Dem RoW	Inequality increases authoritarian inclination in liberal democracies due to the failure of redistributive expectations.
Lee, Y.; Han, S.	2024	Asia	Inequality; Loneliness; Societal fragmentation; South Korea	General rise in inequalities	Sociology	1	2020–2022	1	1	Perceived Inequality	Happiness Survey; Distrust/indifference items	Perceived inequality drives loneliness and societal fragmentation, eroding the trust necessary for social cohesion.
Ronay, R. et al.	2020	Europe	Inequality; leadership; dominance; prestige; evolution	General rise in inequalities	Psychology	0	n/a	1	Global	Resource distribution	Dominance vs. Prestige-based leadership	High resource inequality attracts and favors dominance-oriented leaders who prioritize self-interest over group goals.
Miller, S. V.	2017	North America	Economic threats; Societal threats; Authoritarianism; Political attitudes	General democratic backsliding	Political Science	1	1995–2008	1	83	Gini (Threat index)	World Values Survey	Economic threat (especially income inequality) robustly explains individual preferences for authoritarian rule.

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Authors	Year	Region	Keywords	Motivation	Field	Meth. ^a	Period	LOA ^b	N	Inequality Var.	Democracy Var.	Main Findings
Mortenson, C.; Nisbet, E.	2025	North America	revealed preferences; democratic backsliding; economic inequality; trade-offs	General democratic backsliding	Other	1	2024	1	1	Economic well-being	Conjoint experiment (Revealed preferences)	Americans prioritize material benefits over democratic principles when facing economic disadvantage.
Parsons, B.; Rabhi, A.	2025	North America	Redistribution; Income inequality; Internal conflict; Developing countries	General rise in inequalities	Economics	1	1990–2021	1	93	Market Gini	ICRG Political Regime score	Greater market inequality exacerbates internal conflict, while redistribution reduces the risk of civil disorder and terrorism.
Uzar, U.	2025	Asia	Media control; freedom of expression; income inequality; capture model	General rise in inequalities	Economics	1	1993–2017	1	14	Gini	Freedom House; V-Dem; Whitten-Van Belle	High income inequality catalyzes media capture and government control, eroding press freedom in emerging markets.
Scheiring, G.	2021	Europe	Authoritarianism; State capitalism; backsliding; Dependent development	Specific Geopolitical event	Sociology	0.5	2000–2018	1	1	top income shares	Billionaire press database	Economic elite polarization and the revolt of the national bourgeoisie against dependent development ended liberal democracy.

Notes :^aMethod : 1 = Quantitative, 0 = Qualitative, 0.5 = Mixed-method^bLOA : Level of Analysis (0 = Subnational, 1 = National, 2 = Supranational)

3.1 Characteristics of Sources of Evidence

Temporality and Motivations

Table 3 summarises the principal characteristics of the selected articles. The corpus comprises 24 articles published between 2012 and 2025, with more than half appearing after 2022. The temporal distribution of publications reveals three notable spikes. The first occurs in 2016–2017, the second in 2020–2021, and the third in 2024–2025. These peaks may be concomitant with major social and political events. The first and third spikes coincide with the election and re-election of Donald Trump, while the second aligns with the COVID-19 pandemic. This pattern could suggest that the scientific literature on economic inequalities and democratic backsliding is, at least partly, reactive to major political and societal shocks.

When looking more in detail, relatively little variation is observed in the motivations of the papers. Most studies are motivated by concerns over democratic backsliding in established democracies. Some authors refer to this phenomenon in general terms, emphasising a broader illiberal turn (Brzezinski et al., 2022; Houle, 2024; Uzar, 2025), while others explicitly identify political leaders associated with democratic erosion. For example, Lee et Han (2025), Koos (2025), and Rau et Stokes (2025) directly mention figures such as Donald Trump, Viktor Orbán, or Narendra Modi.

TABLE 3 – Study characteristics ($N = 24$)

Study Characteristics		Count (%)
Year of Publication	2010–2014	3 (12%)
	2015–2019	4 (17%)
	2020–2024	10 (42%)
	2025	7 (29%)
Region	North America	9 (38%)
	Asia	7 (29%)
	Europe	7 (29%)
	Oceania	1 (4%)
Theoretical Field	Economics	10 (42%)
	Political Science	8 (33%)
	Sociology	4 (17%)
	Psychology	1 (4%)
	Other	1 (4%)

Geographical Concentration

Most of the articles were conducted in North America (37%), Asia (29%) and Europe (29%), with only 1 article not belonging to these regions : the one from Islam (2018) from Australia. This denotes a clear monopoly held by the most industrialised regions on the study of democratic backsliding and economic inequalities.

Terminology and Fields

Of the 24 analysed articles, the top used keywords were "inequality" (18%), "democratic backsliding" (8%), "democracy" (7%), "authoritarianism" (2%), "populism" (2%). Also, Acemoglu (2006) was the most frequently cited framework in the literature reviews. The dominance of economics (42%) and political science (33%) in this literature fundamentally shapes the scientific understanding of the inequality–democracy nexus, constructing it primarily as a problem of political economy. This perspective aims to model macro-level, structural relationships—such as how concentrated wealth distorts policy through lobbying (elite power theory) or how the skew of the income distribution alters the median voter's redistributive preferences. Consequently, our knowledge is robust on questions of material incentives, institutional rules, and aggregate electoral outcomes. However, this disciplinary lens carries inherent blind spots, as discussed in the part dedicated to the identification of gaps.

3.2 *Characteristics of Conceptualisations and Theories*

The literature reveals a notable absence of unified conceptual frameworks for democratic backsliding, yet scholars have advanced diverse interpretations of the phenomenon. Analysis of the included studies reveals two distinct approaches to conceptualising democratic backsliding, each reflecting different analytical priorities and methodological commitments.

Deficit-Based Approaches : Democracy as a Baseline

The first approach conceptualises democratic backsliding as the erosion or weakening of established democratic principles. These studies operationalise backsliding through deviation from normative democratic standards, typically grounding their analysis in procedural definitions of democracy.

Basihos (2025) exemplifies this approach by anchoring democratic backsliding in Dahlian democratic theory, defining it as "a weakening of fundamental democratic principles" (p. 1096). The author specifies five core components derived from Dahl (1971) : (i) free and fair elections devoid of fraud, bribery, and coercion; (ii) active citizen participation with freedoms of expression and association; (iii) access to diverse information sources ensuring governmental checks; (iv) citizen control over policy agendas through elections; and (v) protection of individual rights enshrined in these principles.

Similarly, Islam (2018) grounds the analysis of democratic backsliding in institutional capacity, defining democracy as "a political regime where the population of a country chooses its government leaders to influence public policy without undue restrictions," with democratic strength contingent upon civil society institutions that permit free choices (Rivera-Batiz, 2002). Jung et al. (2014) adopts an inclusivity framework, contrasting democracy as "inclusive institutions that give all members of society a say on political decision making" against "extractive regimes that expropriate parts or even the majority of the population of political and economic influence."

Within this approach, some scholars emphasise specific institutional dimensions. Koos (2025) conceptualises democratic backsliding as a backlash against liberal democracy and its core polyarchal features, operationalised through an "Anti-pluralism Index" measuring real-world attacks on institutions and a "Populism Index." Rau et Stokes (2025) focuses on

executive aggrandisement, conceptualising backsliding as "power-aggrandizing elected heads of government flouting norms and institutions," measured through significant declines in V-Dem horizontal and vertical accountability indicators.

Mechanism-Focused Approaches : Processes and Drivers

The second approach eschews comprehensive definitional frameworks in favour of examining specific mechanisms, processes, or societal conditions that drive democratic backsliding. These studies privilege granular analysis of particular causal pathways over broad institutional assessments.

Lee et Han (2025) conceptualises democratic backsliding through citizen-level psychological processes, examining how individuals "turn toward authoritarian solutions that seek to ignore institutional hurdles," operationalised through World Values Survey (WVS) data on inclinations toward authoritarian leadership. This focus on mass attitudes is shared by Miller (2017), who conceptualises backsliding as "state leaders engaging in power grabs and consolidations of executive authority with popular approval," measured via WVS items on preferences for a "strong leader" or "army rule."

Lee et Han (2025) adopt a sociological lens, conceptualising democratic backsliding through societal anomie and alienation as contributors to societal fragmentation, measured by survey proxies for distrust, exploitation, and indifference. In contrast, Mortenson et Nisbet (2025) employs a rational choice framework, conceptualising backsliding as citizens "trading democratic principles for material well-being," measured through revealed preferences in conjoint experiments involving attributes such as political equality and rule of law.

Conceptual Diversity and Analytical Implications

This bifurcation in conceptual approaches reflects broader epistemological differences within the field. Deficit-based approaches offer comprehensive assessments but may obscure the specific causal mechanisms driving backsliding. Mechanism-focused approaches provide granular insights into particular pathways but sacrifice holistic understanding of systemic democratic degradation. As a result, the literature map different kinds of mechanisms and offer a good variety in approaches.

3.3 The Designs : An Overview

Methodological Approaches and Dominant Models

Almost all research strategies were based on statistical analysis of large-N databases (92%) with some varieties in the operationalisation of economic inequalities and democratic backsliding.

A huge majority of studies has used the Gini coefficient (54%) or top income share (20%), as an indicator of economic inequalities against a few for subjective perception (12%), or Palma ratios (4%).

Regarding democratic backslide, a very diverse set of approaches has been used. 71% of the studies rely on public global databases (such as V-Dem for example), while 17% choose national databases, and 12% choose their own measures. Among those who choose public datasets, the most frequents were V-Dem (21%), Polity (21%), World Values Survey (to catch the level of

support for democratic values, 21%), Freedom House (4%), Comparative Study of Electoral Systems (CSES, 4%) for the satisfaction with democracy.

The rest has favoured unique approaches such as the perception of inequalities used by [lee_mapping_2025](#) to examine how subjective representations of economic disparities affect the feeling of loneliness in South Korea, leading to a higher propensity to mistrust others and societal fragmentation. They rely on literature to highlight that this feeling of loneliness represents a particular threat to democratic structures.

Otherwise, two papers escaped from the use of pure statistical models. The first paper mobilises the scientific literature to explain the role of inequalities in the formations of groups, and their consequences in terms of leadership. The one from Ronay et al. (2020) focusing on psychological aspects of inequalities on the selection of leaders. The second one from Scheiring (2021) examining from the point of view of sociology the role of the economic inequalities in the Hungarian democratic backsliding. This quasi-absence of research on the micro-foundations of the link between economic inequalities and democratic backsliding constitutes a core gap, as discussed at the end of this section.

Geographical Scope

The geographical scope is not very varied. Almost every research focuses on a cross-national comparison (75%). Only few exceptions exist. The article from Deinla et al. (2025) is particularly interesting for its originality. Focusing on the Philippines, the authors choosed the individual and regional level of analysis. Instead of directly measuring the effect of economic inequalities on democratic backsliding across countries, authors have led a survey over thousands of Filipino students to assess their support of democracy depending on socio-economic factors. Deinla et al. (2025) argue that there is an "intergenerational disconnect" in democratic values, in which individuals born from the 1980s to early 1990s are more prone to be disillusioned with democracy, and more inclined to support illiberalism and populism. It is argued that economic inequalities foster authoritarian nostalgia, conducting in a growing support of strongmen with superficial trust. Authors found that, across Filipino youth, economic inequalities underpin most authoritarian attitudes. However, this study focuses on self-reported income of respondents to predict their support for democratic institutions. As a result, we learn about how attitudes vary depending on how poor or how rich individuals are but not depending on by how much the difference between rich and poor individuals affects the aggregated support for democratic principles.

Interestingly, there is a total absence of studies focusing on the role of inequalities on the democratic crisis at supra-national level. In an era of global governance, democratic crisis, and rising economic inequalities, there is a clear motivation to fulfil this vacuum.

3.4 The Impact of Economic Inequalities on Democratic Backsliding

The mechanisms theorised about the impact of economic inequalities on democratic backsliding are diverse and offer a comprehensive picture of institutional decay. These explanations can be clustered into three groups : (i) elite economic empowerment and institutional erosion ; (ii) increased support for non-democratic leadership ; and (iii) the systematic erosion of public support for democratic values.

The first relationship concerns the faculty of elites to transform market power into political power. Basihos (2025) argues that the concentration of market power among a restricted set of firms leads to a concentration of political power that undermines democracy. Using panel data on 80 countries, this research associates higher market power with decreasing clean election qualities, reduced political accountability, and increased media bias and corruption. This reflects a "captured democracy" where the rich monopolise political influence, preventing the state from responding to the needs of ordinary citizens. Furthermore, Rau et Stokes (2025) identify economic inequality as one of the strongest predictors of where and when democracy erodes, establishing that it fuels "pernicious polarisation" that aggrandising leaders exploit to flout horizontal and vertical accountability. In emerging markets, high inequality often acts as a catalyst for media capture, allowing governments to control the flow of information to protect existing power relations.

The second group explains backsliding through the support for strong, personalist leadership. Research indicates that individuals identifying with the extreme ends of the subjective class spectrum—both the "very low" and "very high"—show a significantly higher propensity to favour strongman leadership that bypasses institutional constraints like parliament or elections. Ronay et al. (2020) suggest that higher levels of inequality attract and favour dominance-oriented leaders who prioritise self-interest and use coercion to maintain rank, rather than prestige-based leaders who prioritise group welfare. Miller (2017) finds that economic threats, particularly income inequality, robustly explain individual preferences for authoritarian rule as citizens seek to "escape from freedom" and the alienation of modern economic systems. In these contexts, many citizens become "benefit seekers," willing to trade democratic principles for material well-being and security.

Third, inequalities generate lower support for democracy as a value. Krieckhaus et al. (2014) find that economic inequality is the single largest determinant of democratic support, as citizens retrospectively evaluate the regime's performance based on its redistributive failures. Similarly, Andersen (2012) demonstrates that national income inequality reduces support for democracy across both established and former Communist nations. Beyond individual attitudes, wealth inequality shrinks the subjective middle class—the demographic most consistently aligned with democratic values—leaving institutions more vulnerable. In liberal democracies, the failure to meet citizens' redistributive expectations can increase authoritarian inclinations and social fragmentation, as individuals feel alienated from an unresponsive political system.

The theoretical diversity of the literature is one of its major strengths. By offering such different mechanisms to the same relationship, it provides robust evidence that economic inequalities constitute a primary driver of democratic backsliding in the 21st century.

3.5 Gaps in the Research

As discussed during the presentation of the results, few gaps exist and need to be fulfilled. First on the production of knowledge. Critical work on the colonality of global knowledge production shows that the dominance of Western institutions does not only reflect capacity differences; it also institutionalises Eurocentric epistemologies as the default mode of theorising. Northern universities and journals define the "frontier" of theory, while Southern scholars are often structurally positioned as providers of empirical material, constrained by English-language publication regimes, funding structures, and ranking systems that privilege Northern debates. This disparity matters for our understanding of democratic dynamics since in the

broader social sciences, such concentration is part of what decolonial and postcolonial scholars describe as a "core-periphery" structure of academia, in which Northern institutions set agendas, concepts, and methods, while Southern contexts are reduced to data sites rather than sources of theory. This geographical skew could matter substantively because it means that the dominant operationalisation of "democracy" and "quality of democracy" are likely to be calibrated on Western experiences and expectations, and then applied globally as if they were neutral yardsticks. However, this critique is moderated by the fact that the study is subject to selection bias due to the English language requirement.

Second, the relative scarcity of sociological (17%) and psychological (4%) perspectives, coupled with quasi-absence of qualitative approaches (8%) means the field has a comparatively underdeveloped understanding of the micro-foundational and socio-cultural mechanisms that translate objective inequality into anti-democratic political behaviour. Specifically, it risks overlooking how pervasive inequality reshapes social relations, collective identities, and individual psychology. There is a need to better theorise and measure how different forms of inequality (e.g., wealth vs income, regional disparities, intergenerational immobility, gendered or colonial) may trigger distinct social and political reactions. Future research that deliberately integrates sociological theories of social cohesion and psychological theories of threat perception could bridge this crucial explanatory gap.

Third, interestingly no studies have measured the transnational effect of economic inequalities on the democracy of others. It is relatively easy to imagine that the elite-capture or elite influence have effects not bounded by territory. The many examples of interferences by colonial powers to favour a government over another in time of election in a foreign country illustrate this effect. The more the power of domestic elites, the more likely they have international interests due to globalisation, so the more likely the democratic backsliding of connected countries. For example, the social media favouritism to extreme-right content could have been tackled or mitigated if they were not possessed by only one majoritarian shareholder. Alternatively, the many private donations to far-right parties are allowed by an extremely exacerbated structure of inequalities. I think this represents the main failure of the literature, and this review is a desperate call to fulfil this gap.

Fourth, the dominance of Gini and top income shares in the corpus implies that most of the literature operationalises "inequality" as overall income dispersion (or elite income concentration) and therefore risks under-detecting distributional patterns (e.g., bottom-heavy deprivation, wealth gaps, spatial or group inequalities) that could be more relevant for democratic backsliding mechanisms. Since Gini compresses the full distribution into a single scalar, different distributive regimes (e.g., very rich top 1% vs squeezed middle vs impoverished bottom) can yield similar values, which may blur theoretically distinct channels like elite capture, mass resentment, or middle-class exit. Gini often misses whether inequality is driven by the very top or by the impoverishment of the bottom, and that results can change once one decomposes inequality into "bottom-concentrated" vs "top-concentrated" components (Blesch et al., 2022). Also, policy-oriented work on backsliding notes that Gini is "unreliable and often misleading" in many middle-income countries experiencing erosion, pointing to cases like Brazil where falling Gini coexists with persistently extreme inequality in wealth and top incomes (as seen in the World Inequality Database). Combining Gini with top/bottom shares is explicitly proposed in the inequality measurement literature as a way to distinguish which part of the distribution drives observed relationships. The Palma (top 10% share / bottom 40% share) is designed to be "over-sensitive" to changes at the extremes and easier to interpret substantively, which is

appealing for democratic backsliding debates centred on elite capture versus mass exclusion. Several analysts argue that Palma better reflects the social impact of inequality and that changes in Palma often align more closely with observable political tensions than changes in Gini.

Fifth, and probably the consequence of the occidental monopoly on the debate, the focus is very narrow in terms of form of democracy. For instance, influential indices such as Freedom House, V-Dem, or liberal democracy scales tend to embed liberal individualist norms (civil liberties, competitive elections, party pluralism) as core, while treating other dimensions—like communal decision-making, socio-economic equality, or collective rights—as optional add-ons or secondary outcomes. Absolutely no studies have looked at other forms of democracy. Here also, the theoretical mechanisms of inequality conflating with democratic principles should apply and need to be measured in order to tackle this threat.

4. DISCUSSION

This scoping review is subject to several limitations inherent to its design and operational choices. First, the review is constrained by its search and selection protocol. While the use of two major multidisciplinary databases (Web of Science and Scopus) ensures a focus on high-impact, peer-reviewed literature and enhances reproducibility, it necessarily excludes relevant works published in books, book chapters, working paper series, or journals not indexed in these databases. This is particularly consequential for capturing scholarship from the Global South or interdisciplinary work published in area studies or less prominent outlets, potentially reinforcing the very "core-periphery" bias in knowledge production that the review identifies. Furthermore, the restriction to English-language publications introduces a significant linguistic and, by extension, reinforces the geographical bias.

Second, the temporal scope of the review (2000–2025), while justified by a focus on 21st-century trends, excludes foundational theoretical and empirical work from the late 20th century that established the classic frameworks linking distributional conflict to regime type. While this choice sharpens the review's relevance to contemporary debates on backsliding (as opposed to democratic transitions or breakdowns), it may obscure longer-term historical trajectories and path dependencies that are essential for a fully contextualised understanding.

Third, the screening and data charting process, though conducted systematically, involved a degree of subjective judgement. Decisions on whether a study's primary focus constituted an empirical test of the inequality–backsliding link were made by a single reviewer. While a strategy of inclusive screening during the abstract phase mitigated the risk of premature exclusion, the final eligibility assessment and the coding of complex items—such as theoretical frameworks or the conceptualisation of democracy—remain interpretative. The use of a second, independent reviewer for a subset of studies or the application of formal inter-coder reliability tests in complement to the intra-coder assessment would have strengthened the objectivity of the selection and charting process.

Fourth, by design, a scoping review does not formally assess the quality or risk of bias of the included studies, nor does it synthesise effect sizes through meta-analysis. Consequently, this map of the literature treats all empirical studies as contributing equally to the field's landscape, regardless of their methodological rigour, identification strategies, or susceptibility to confounding. The review can identify that a relationship is frequently tested and report the direction of findings, but it cannot adjudicate the strength or causality of the relationship. The

preponderance of large-N cross-national regression studies noted in the results carries its own set of methodological limitations—such as equating different forms of backsliding, relying on observational data, and potentially overlooking causal heterogeneity—which this review records but does not critically evaluate in depth.

Finally, the analytical focus of the review, while comprehensive, necessarily prioritises certain dimensions over others. The charting of items was designed to capture broad patterns in conceptualisation, method, and geography. As a result, finer-grained analyses—such as a detailed typology of mediating mechanisms or a systematic comparison of how different democracy indices yield divergent results—are beyond its primary scope. These areas represent fruitful avenues for subsequent, more targeted systematic reviews.

Nevertheless, these limitations do not undermine the central value of this review in mapping a fragmented field and identifying critical gaps. Rather, they explicitly define the boundaries of the synthesised evidence and underscore that the presented findings are a function of specific methodological choices. Future research can build upon this foundation by expanding search parameters, incorporating quality appraisal, and delving deeper into the specific thematic and methodological sub-questions that this broad scoping exercise has brought to light.

5. CONCLUSION

This scoping review provides the first systematic map of the empirical literature examining the relationship between economic inequality and democratic backsliding, synthesising evidence from 24 peer-reviewed articles published between 2012 and 2025. The corpus reveals a field characterised by significant disciplinary concentration, methodological homogeneity, and geographical imbalance, yet also marked by notable theoretical diversity in proposed causal mechanisms.

Addressing Research Question 1, the temporal distribution of publications shows three distinct peaks (2016–2017, 2020–2021, and 2024–2025) that correspond to major political shocks—the election and re-election of Donald Trump and the COVID-19 pandemic—suggesting that scholarship in this domain is at least partially reactive to contemporary crises rather than driven by endogenous theoretical development. Geographically, the literature is overwhelmingly produced in North America (38%), Europe (29%), and Asia (29%), with minimal representation from Africa, Latin America, or Oceania. This concentration reflects broader patterns of inequity in global knowledge production and raises concerns about whether dominant conceptualisations of democracy and backsliding are calibrated primarily to Western institutional contexts.

Regarding Research Question 2, the review identifies substantial variation in how scholars conceptualise and operationalise both inequality and democratic backsliding. Economic inequality is predominantly measured using the Gini coefficient (54%) or top income shares (20%), with limited attention to alternative metrics such as the Palma ratio, wealth inequality, or subjective perceptions of economic disparity. Democratic backsliding is operationalised through a diverse array of measures, including established indices (V-Dem, Polity, Freedom House) capturing institutional degradation, survey data on democratic support (World Values Survey), and bespoke indicators tailored to specific contexts. Methodologically, the field is dominated by large-N cross-national regression analyses (92%), with qualitative and mixed-methods approaches constituting only 8% of the corpus. This near-exclusivity of quantitative methods reflects the disciplinary dominance of economics (42%) and political science (33%),

while sociology (17%) and psychology (4%) remain marginal.

Theoretically, the literature offers three primary clusters of explanation for how inequality erodes democracy : (i) elite economic empowerment translating into institutional capture and erosion of accountability ; (ii) mass-level dynamics in which inequality fosters support for authoritarian leaders or populist strongmen ; and (iii) inequality undermining normative commitment to democratic values among citizens. This theoretical pluralism is a strength, as it suggests multiple, potentially reinforcing pathways through which economic disparities destabilise democratic systems. However, the micro-foundational mechanisms—how inequality reshapes social relations, collective identities, trust, and individual psychology—remain under-theorised and under-investigated.

Addressing Research Question 3, the review identifies five critical gaps. First, the geographical concentration of scholarship in the Global North institutionalises Eurocentric epistemologies and risks operationalising democracy in ways that privilege liberal-procedural definitions while marginalising alternative democratic traditions. Second, the scarcity of sociological and psychological perspectives limits understanding of the socio-cultural and affective mechanisms linking objective inequality to anti-democratic behaviour. Third, no studies examine transnational spillovers—how inequality in one country might influence democratic stability in others through elite networks, global media, or cross-border political financing. Fourth, the dominance of the Gini coefficient risks obscuring distributional nuances (e.g., whether inequality is driven by extreme wealth concentration at the top or deprivation at the bottom) that may activate distinct political responses. Fifth, the exclusive focus on liberal-procedural democracy neglects other democratic forms, such as participatory, deliberative, or communal models, which may exhibit different vulnerabilities to inequality.

The findings carry important implications for both scholarship and policy. For researchers, the identified gaps point toward several productive avenues for future inquiry : expanding geographical coverage to include under-studied regions, particularly in the Global South ; integrating sociological and psychological frameworks to examine how inequality reshapes social relations, collective identities, and individual affect ; investigating transnational spillovers and cross-border elite networks ; employing more distributionally sensitive inequality measures beyond the Gini coefficient ; and broadening the conceptual scope to examine non-liberal democratic forms. Methodologically, there is a clear need for qualitative and mixed-methods research that can trace causal processes, capture contextual specificity, and generate theory grounded in diverse empirical settings rather than solely testing hypotheses derived from Western cases.

For policymakers, the review underscores that economic inequality poses a multi-faceted threat to democratic stability, operating through institutional, behavioural, and normative channels. Effective responses must therefore be similarly multi-dimensional, addressing not only the material distribution of resources but also the political influence of economic elites, the social fragmentation wrought by extreme disparities, and the erosion of democratic culture among citizens. The geographical concentration of research also suggests that policy debates may be overly influenced by Northern experiences and institutional templates, potentially overlooking context-specific pathways and solutions relevant to consolidating democracies or mixed regimes in other regions.

Ultimately, this review demonstrates that while the empirical study of inequality and democratic

backsliding has gained momentum in recent years—particularly in response to visible political crises—it remains an intellectually and geographically fragmented field. The diversity of causal mechanisms proposed across studies suggests that inequality’s relationship to democracy is genuinely complex and multifaceted, rather than reducible to a single universal logic. This complexity demands continued theoretical refinement, methodological pluralism, and deliberate efforts to decentre Western epistemologies and incorporate voices, contexts, and democratic traditions from across the globe. Only through such broadening can the field generate knowledge adequate to the global challenge of sustaining democracy in an era of rising inequality.

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